

Session 17: The Dragon in the Waters

Key Takeaways

- The *tannin*, or mythical sea dragon, is created on day five with the other sea creatures. It symbolizes disorder, chaos, and death throughout the Bible, but the creation story shows that the *tannin* is simply one of Yahweh's creatures.
- The forces of chaos in the Bible, represented by the waters and the sea dragon, affect human life, but ultimately, they are created things that will be overcome by God himself.

Revisit of the Design Structure of Days Four Through Six

Day 4: God Delegates Heavenly Rulers

14 And God said,
"Let there be lights
in the expanse of the skies
to separate the day from the night,
and let them be for signs
and for festivals and for days and years;
15 and let them be for lights
in the dome of the skies
to give light on the land";
and it was so.
16 And God made the two great lights,
the great light to rule the day,
and the small light to rule the night;
and also the stars.
17 And God placed them
in the dome of the skies
to give light on the land,
18 and to rule the day and the night,
and to separate the light from the darkness;
and God saw that it was good.

19 And there was evening
and there was morning,

a fourth day.

Day 5: God Apportions the Waters Above and Below

20 **And God said,**

A "Let **the waters** swarm with swarms of living creatures,
and let birds fly **above the land**
against the face of the dome of the **skies**."

21 And God created the great sea monsters
and every living creature that moves,

B with which the waters swarmed after their kind,
and every bird of wing after its kind;
and God saw that it was good.

22 And God blessed them, saying,

A' "Be fruitful and multiply,
and fill **the waters in the seas**,
and let birds multiply on the land."

23 And there was evening
and there was morning,

a fifth day.

Day 6: God Delegates Earthly Rulers

24 **And God said,**

"**Let the land** bring out living creatures
according to their kind,
cattle
and creeping things
and beasts of the land
according to their kind";
and it was so.

25 And God made

the beasts of the land
according to their kind,
and the cattle
according to their kind,
and the creepers of the ground
according to its kind;

and God saw that it was good.

26 **And God said,**

"Let us **make human**

in our image,
according to our likeness;
and let them **rule**
over the fish of the sea
and over the birds of the sky
and over the cattle
and over all the land
and over every creeper that creeps on the land ."

27 And God created human in his image,
in the image of God he created him ;
male and female he created them .

28 And God blessed them ,
"Be fruitful and multiply,
and fill the land,
and subdue it;
and rule
over the fish of the sea
and over the birds of the sky
and over every living creature that creeps on the land ."

29 And God said,
"Behold, I have given to you
every plant producing seed
that is on the surface of all the earth,
and every tree which has fruit producing seed ;
it shall be food for you;
30 and to every beast of the land
and to every bird of the sky
and to every thing that moves on the land
which has animal life in it,
every green plant for food";
and it was so.

31 And God saw all that he had made,
and behold, it was very good.

And there was evening
and there was morning,
a sixth day .

The Dragon in the Waters

Genesis 1:21 alludes to a tradition of great sea monsters that lived in the ocean. Wait, seriously—sea monsters? Let's take a look.

Genesis 1:21 NASB

God created the **great sea monsters** and every living creature that moves, with which the waters swarmed after their kind, and every winged bird after its kind; and God saw that it was good.

The Hebrew word used here for “sea monster” is *tannin* (תנין). This word is used to refer to the mythical sea dragons elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible.

Other texts in the Hebrew Bible describe creation as a cosmic victory of Yahweh in which he shatters the heads of chaos dragons.

Psalms 74:12-17 NIV

12 But God is my King from long ago;
he brings salvation on the earth.
13 It was you who **split open the sea** by your power;
you **broke the heads of the sea monster in the waters.**
14 It was you who **crushed the heads of Leviathan**
and gave it as food to the creatures of the desert.
15 It was you who opened up springs and streams;
you dried up the ever-flowing rivers.
16 The day is yours, and yours also the night;
you established the sun and moon.
17 It was you who set all the boundaries of the earth;
you made both summer and winter.

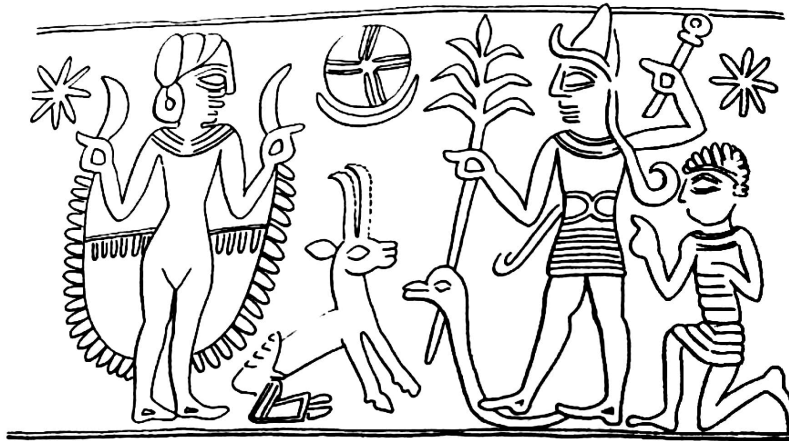
Job 26:10-14 NIV

10 He marks out the horizon on the face of the waters
for a boundary between light and darkness.
11 The pillars of the heavens quake,
aghast at his rebuke.
12 By his power he **churned up the sea**;
by his wisdom he **cut Rahab to pieces.**
13 By his breath the skies became fair;
his hand pierced the gliding serpent.
14 And these are but the outer fringe of his works;
how faint the whisper we hear of him!
Who then can understand the thunder of his power?

Psalms 89:8-13 NIV

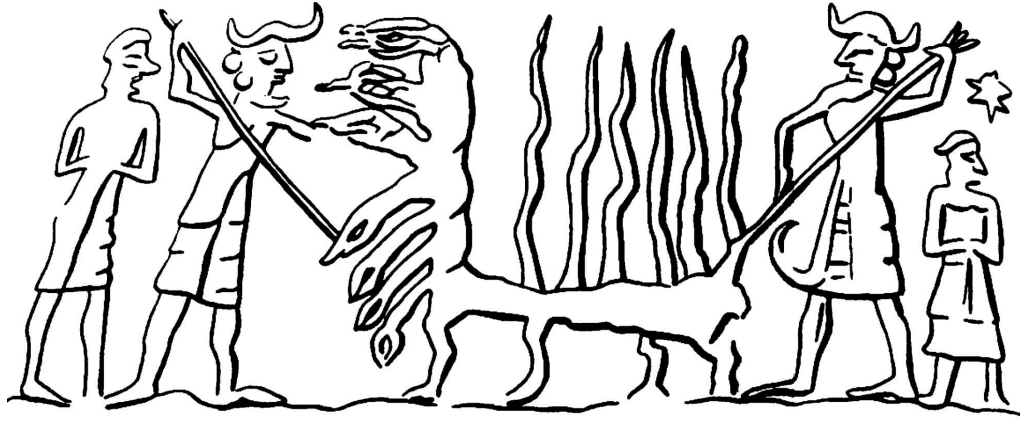
⁸ Who is like you, LORD God Almighty?
You, LORD, are mighty, and your faithfulness surrounds you.
⁹ You rule over the surging sea;
when its waves mount up, you still them.
¹⁰ You crushed Rahab like one of the slain;
with your strong arm you scattered your enemies.
¹¹ The heavens are yours, and yours also the earth;
you founded the world and all that is in it.
¹² You created the north and the south;
Tabor and Hermon sing for joy at your name.
¹³ Your arm is endowed with power;
your hand is strong, your right hand exalted.

Dragon Smashing in Babylonian and Canaanite Cosmology



Keel, Othmar (2015). *Creation: Biblical Theologies in the Context of the Ancient Near East*. Eisenbrauns.

A Syrian cylinder seal from 18th-17th century B.C.E. depicts Baal crushing a snake. A Syrian goddess (left) calls upon Baal the storm god (right). Baal stomps on a snake while piercing its head with a spear. A kneeling worshiper looks on (far right).



Keel, Othmar (2015). *Creation: Biblical Theologies in the Context of the Ancient Near East*. Eisenbrauns.

A cylinder seal from Tell-Asmar (2300 B.C.E.) depicts two horned deities as they thrust spears into a seven-headed dragon. The two gods are flanked by worshippers.

These images correlate with a Canaanite epic known as the Baal and Anat epic, dating to the 14th century B.C.E. The story was among the Ugaritic tablets found north of Israel in the 1920s. There was a temple to Baal with many texts profiling his exploits and rise to power. In a crucial scene, Baal defeats the forces of chaos to become a cosmic king and build his royal palace. Notably, the powers of chaos that Baal overcomes are *Yam* ("sea" in Hebrew) and *Nahar* ("river" in Hebrew), who are portrayed together as a great, multiheaded dragon-snake!

Similarly, there are other creation texts in the Hebrew Bible where the sea itself is the chaos monster, taking the place of the dragon image.

Psalm 104:6-9 NASB

⁶ You covered it with the deep as with a garment;
the waters were standing above the mountains.

⁷ At your rebuke they fled,
at the sound of your thunder they hurried away.

⁸ The mountains rose; the valleys sank down
to the place which you established for them.

⁹ You set a boundary that they may not pass over,
so that they will not return to cover the earth.

Job 38:8-11 NASB

⁸ Or who enclosed the sea with doors
when, bursting forth, it went out from the womb;

⁹ when I made a cloud its garment
and thick darkness its swaddling band,

¹⁰ and I placed boundaries on it
and set a bolt and doors,

¹¹ and I said, "Thus far you shall come, but no farther;
and here shall your proud waves stop"?

Even though Yahweh is depicted as victorious over the sea-dragon at creation, the Hebrew Bible is very clear that he did not eliminate the dragon. Those same chaos monsters are behind every event of disorder and death in human history that threatens God's good order.

- In [Psalm 74](#), Yahweh's defeat of the dragon at creation makes the destruction of the temple even more painful, so the poet calls for the defeat of the dragon once again.
- In [Isaiah 51:9-11](#), the poet calls for God to redo the exodus event, which was a defeat of the chaos dragon that had enslaved Israel. The dragon is loose again in the events of Jerusalem's destruction and exile, and the dragon needs to be dealt with.
- In [Job 41](#), the chaos dragon Leviathan is still alive, and only Yahweh can subdue it.

"In each of these texts [Ps. 74; Isa. 51; Job 41], the confinement of chaos rather than its elimination is the essence of creation, and the survival of ordered reality hangs only upon God's vigilance in ensuring that those cosmic dikes do not fail, that the bars of the Sea's jail cell do not give way ... [These images] testify both to the precariousness of life, its absolute dependence upon God, and the sureness and firmness of life under the protection of the faithful master. The world is not inherently safe, but inherently unsafe. Only the magisterial intervention of God and his eternal vigilance prevent the cataclysm."

Levenson, Jon (1994). [Creation and the Persistence of Evil](#). Princeton University Press. 17.

Chaos Water and Sea Beasts in a Modern Worldview

"Genesis 1:2 depicts the pre-creation state as an unholy trinity: wilderness, darkness, and cosmic chaos waters. However, within the Bible itself, these chaos waters can be depicted metaphorically as the chaos dragon, and in this way, the symbolic meaning of the waters remains a viable idea today.

In the Bible, water and sea beasts function as evocative symbols of overwhelming and powerful chaos-inducing forces. They remind us that God's creation is good but not tame. There are forces beyond human control that should be treated with respect, because when they exceed their bounds they are destructive. At a metaphorical level dragons and wild oceans remain helpful symbols of chaos that can invade communal and individual human worlds, threatening order and life itself. Within the Bible the symbol is used to describe political oppression and the collapse of order in the lives of communities and people. At a metaphysical level ... Genesis 1 depicts a creation that, left to itself, would collapse back into chaos. The world does not sustain or order itself. It is God who ordered and continues to order reality ... But the tendency towards disorder is inherent within the world ... The sea represents non-being, literally 'no-thing.'

Taking this approach, we might consider evil, portrayed as chaos waters or sea beasts, as a tendency in creation to move away from being and form toward nothingness. Here we find Augustine's helpful idea that evil is not a thing as such, but a lack of substance and form, a privation. Evil is what remains when goodness has fallen away from something's nature. On this approach, the sea and the dragon are symbols of meaninglessness, creation that has fallen from its intended purpose. Conceived in this way, evil has no purpose or being, it is literally nothing, and has no meaning at all. That, of course, is what is so terrible about it."

Design Patterns: God as the Master Water Tamer

God has total mastery over the dark, chaos waters of Genesis 1:2, but those forces of chaos still exist and threaten the world.

Genesis 1: God as the Water Tamer

Genesis 1:1-2	Genesis 1:3-5	Genesis 1:6-8	Genesis 1:9-10
God creates by means of his Spirit hovering over the dark, cosmic waters of "wild and waste" that make human communities impossible.	Day 1 "Let there be light' and there was light. And God saw that the light was good, and he separated between the light and between the darkness."	Day 2 "Let there be a dome, and it will separate between the waters below the dome and the waters above the dome."	Day 3 "Let the waters under the skies gather together (קוה) into one place and let the dry land (יבשה) become visible."
God the Water Tamer. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Heaven and Earth (2019).			

Genesis 6-8: The Flood as De-Creation and Re-Creation

The flood is presented as a de-creation. In Genesis 7:11, "the springs of the cosmic deep waters (תהום) split (נבקע) and the windows of the heavens are opened" (i.e., reversing days two and three of creation).

Genesis 7:22-23 NASB*

²² ... Of all that was on the dry ground, and all in whose nostrils was the breath of life (נשמת־רוח חיים), died.

²³ And every being was wiped away that was on the face of the ground, from human (אדם), to beast, to creeper, to bird of the skies ... but Noah remained (שאר) and those with him in the ark.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

In this passage, there is an undoing of all the inhabitants from days five and six of creation.

Genesis 8:1, 3 NASB*

¹ But God remembered Noah ... and God caused a *ruakh* to pass (עבר) over the land, ³ and the waters decreased ... and the waters turned back (המים וישבו) from upon the land.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Genesis 8:13-14 NASB*

¹³ And it came about on the 601st year, on the first of the month, the waters dried up (חרב) from upon the land ... ¹⁴ And by the second month on the 14th day, Noah looked and behold, the land was dried up (יבש).

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Joshua 3: Crossing Through the Waters Into the Promised Land

Take notice of any creation imagery in the following passages, specifically the waters and the dry land.

Joshua 3:1 Instructor's Translation

And Joshua awoke in the morning and set out from Shittim and they came to the Jordan, and they stayed the night there before they crossed over.

Joshua 3:2-4

The people are instructed to wait for the priests to carry the ark across first, which will tell them the way to cross the river.

Joshua 3:5 Instructor's Translation

Joshua said to the people, "Make yourselves holy, for tomorrow Yahweh will do wonders in your midst."

Joshua 3:7 Instructor's Translation

Yahweh said to Joshua, "Today I will begin to make you great in the eyes of all Israel, so they will know that just as I was with Moses, I will be with you."

Joshua 3:16-17 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ [The priests' feet touched the river] and the waters of the Jordan were cut off where they flowed up above, and they stood in a single heap ... ¹⁷ And the people crossed across from Jericho, and the priests stood carrying the ark of the covenant of Yahweh on dry ground (ערבה), standing in the midst of the Jordan, while all Israel was crossing on dry ground until all the nation had finished.

The Waters in Isaiah 11 and 51

In Isaiah 11:1-16, we read about a new king from the line of David who is endowed by the Spirit.

Isaiah 11:10 Instructor's Translation

And it will come about on the day, the root of Jesse will stand as a banner for the peoples, and the nations will seek him out, and his resting place will be glory.

Isaiah 11:11-12, 16 Instructor's Translation

¹¹ And it will come about on the day, the Lord will again use his arm a second time, to purchase the remainder (שאר) of his people which remains (שאר) in Assyria, Egypt, Pathros, Cush, Elam, Babylon, and the islands of the sea. ¹² And he will lift up a banner to the nations, and gather the scattered ones of Israel, and he will regather the dispersed ones of Judah ... ¹⁶ And there will be a highway for the remainder (שאר) of his

people who remain (שאר) from Assyria, just as there was for Israel on the day he came up from the land of Egypt.

Notice the language of “remainder.” Other examples of remainders in the biblical story include Noah, Israel rescued from Egypt by Moses, and exiles rescued by the new David.

Isaiah 51:9-11 NIV*

⁹ Awake, awake, arm of the LORD, clothe yourself with strength! Awake, as in days gone by, as in generations of old. Was it not you who cut Rahab to pieces, who pierced the sea monster through? ¹⁰ Was it not you who dried up the sea, the waters of the great deep, who made a road in the depths of the sea so that the redeemed might cross over? ¹¹ Those the LORD has ransomed will return. They will enter Zion with singing; everlasting joy will crown their heads. Gladness and joy will overtake them, and sorrow and sighing will flee away.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Let's skip ahead to Jesus' baptism and walking on the sea (not the waters) in the Gospel of Mark.

Mark 1:9-11 NASB

⁹ In those days Jesus came from Nazareth in Galilee and was baptized by John in the Jordan River. ¹⁰ Immediately coming up out of the water, he saw the heavens opening, and the Spirit like a dove descending upon him; ¹¹ and a voice came out of the heavens: “You are my beloved Son, in you I am well-pleased.”

Mark 4:35-41 NASB

³⁵ On that day, when evening came, he said to them, “Let us go over to the other side.” ³⁶ Leaving the crowd, they took him along with them in the boat, just as he was; and other boats were with him. ³⁷ And there arose a fierce gale of wind, and the waves were breaking over the boat so much that the boat was already filling up. ³⁸ Jesus himself was in the stern, asleep on the cushion; and they woke him and said to him, “Teacher, do you not care that we are perishing?” ³⁹ And he got up and rebuked the wind and said to the sea, “Hush, be still.” And the wind died down and it became perfectly calm. ⁴⁰ And he said to them, “Why are you afraid? How is it that you have no faith?” ⁴¹ They became very much afraid and said to one another, “Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?”

Jesus rebuking the sea echoes back to Yahweh rebuking the waters in [Nahum 1:4](#) and [Psalm 106:9](#). Jesus walking on the sea echoes back to Yahweh treading on the sea in [Job 9:8](#).

The Sea and Monsters in Daniel 7 and Revelation 13 and 21

Daniel 7:2-7 NASB

² Daniel said, “I was looking in my vision by night, and behold, the four winds of heaven were stirring up the great sea. ³ And four great beasts were coming up from the sea, different from one another. ⁴ The first was like a lion and had the wings of an eagle ... ⁵ And behold, another beast, a second one, resembling a bear. And it was raised up on one side, and three ribs were in its mouth between its teeth; and thus they said to

it, 'Arise, devour much meat!' ⁶ After this I kept looking, and behold, another one, like a leopard, which had on its back four wings of a bird; the beast also had four heads, and dominion was given to it. ⁷ After this I kept looking in the night visions, and behold, a fourth beast, dreadful and terrifying and extremely strong; and it had large iron teeth. It devoured and crushed and trampled down the remainder with its feet; and it was different from all the beasts that were before it, and it had ten horns."

Revelation 13:1-2 NASB

¹ And the dragon stood on the sand of the seashore. Then I saw a beast coming up out of the sea, having ten horns and seven heads, and on his horns were ten diadems, and on his heads were blasphemous names. ² And the beast which I saw was like a leopard, and his feet were like those of a bear, and his mouth like the mouth of a lion. And the dragon gave him his power and his throne and great authority.

Revelation 21:1 NASB

Then I saw a new heaven and a new earth; for the first heaven and the first earth passed away, and there is no longer any sea.

Reflection Question

A *tannin*, like the one created on day five, is a mythical sea dragon throughout the Bible. What does the *tannin* symbolize? What is significant about it being highlighted on day five?